

The 2027 Medieval English Theatre Conference will take place on 9th-10th April in Fribourg, Switzerland.

The theme is 'Narratives of Family and Sacrifice'.

Note for regular attendees of MEdTh:

On Saturday 10th April there will be the usual MEdTh event, with speakers presenting research on early theatre, in single-strand sessions. You are invited to submit proposals as usual (see the CFP below).

On Friday 9th April there will be a supplementary event with (some) structured panels, including invited speakers, that will be sponsored by our WOMARD project (www.womard.org). For this we would like to include scholars from history of art and theology as well as literature and theatre, and to consider these themes in Judaism, Christianity and Islam.

We hope to host ta'zیه and purimshpil performances by established troupes, though this is not yet certain. We hope also to present an English Abraham and Isaac play.

Obviously MEdTh people will be welcome to attend the whole thing, or simply the Friday night and Saturday as usual (there will be dinners on the Friday night but also on the Thursday night (8th April) for scholars who cannot attend on Friday evening).

We hope to offer a limited number of bursaries to assist with the travel and accommodation costs of those presenting papers: please indicate in your submission if you would like to be considered for one of these.

Call for Papers:

Narratives of sacrifice have inspired dramatists of many traditions. Jesus's sacrifice on the cross is central to the medieval cycle plays, and Mary is the archetypal mother who suffers at the sacrifice of her son: her lament at the foot of the cross, which was the subject of numerous lyrics, is incorporated into the medieval dramatic tradition alongside the complaint of her crucified son, who calls on passers-by to attend to his suffering and understand their role in it. God's sacrifice of His Son is foreshadowed by Abraham's almost-sacrifice of Isaac; concern to foreground this typological father-son reading is perhaps the reason that Sarah, Isaac's mother, is absent from the cycle plays: however, Sarah is a significant figure in the Northampton *Abraham and Isaac* play which focuses less on typology than on 'the dangers of patriarchal absolutism' and 'the resulting conflicts of emotions and loyalties that affect father, mother, and child' (Mills 2009, 70). There are other biblical narratives of family and sacrifice: Cain's jealousy over God's preference for Abel's sacrifice inspires the first murder, a fratricide; the story also appears in the cycle plays. A female counterpart to the almost-sacrificed Isaac, Jephthah's daughter is willing to be killed by her father for the people of Israel: her story becomes a subject for early modern playwrights such as George Buchanan, whose Latin *Jephthes, sive Votum*, 1554 was translated into many European vernaculars. *Jephthes* imitates the structure of Euripides' *Iphigenia in Aulis*, a classical Greek play about a daughter sacrificed by her father to his cause: Buchanan highlights this influence by naming Jephthah's daughter Iphis; he also creates a role for Iphis' mother.

The Binding ('*Akeidah*') of Isaac has also great significance in Jewish tradition, which sees Abraham, Sarah and Isaac as the first Jewish family, saved from annihilation by God's salvation of Isaac: *Purimshpil* dealing with the topic are a very late development, but the '*Akeidah*' was also the central topic of a collection of Hebrew liturgical poems, '*Akeidah piyyutim*', which were recited during penitential prayers on High Holidays and provoked strong emotional and religious feelings among listeners as the bound Isaac became an image of the persecuted Jews of medieval Europe. In Islamic versions of the story, it is not Isaac that Abraham must sacrifice, but Ishmael, his son by Hajar, an Egyptian slave: parallels are drawn between the willing nature of Abraham and Ishmael's sacrifice and the self-sacrificial death of Husain, grandson of the Prophet Mohammed, whose death is central to Shi'i salvation doctrine and the ta'zیه plays.

The fascination of these narratives may lie partly in the ethical struggles that cause family loyalty to be overridden by devotion to God and nation, and partly in the horror of the thought that siblings and, especially, parents may raise violent hands to those whom, naturally, they should protect. Dramatising such stories provides opportunities to realise their horror potently and to lay out the hideous dilemmas that in many cases their protagonists face. Of course, as an art form that depends on the actor's body, theatre is also in many ways the perfect medium for stories of bodily suffering: on the other hand, realizing physical injury and death onstage offers considerable material challenges. How, theatrically, can bodies be whipped, limbs severed, blood made to flow? And can these effects be achieved while stirring only appropriate religious sentiment in the viewer?

Papers might address early plays about Abraham and Isaac/Ishmael, Sarah/Hajar, or Jephthah's daughter, or Cain and Abel, or the Holy Family, or the crucifixion or Mary at the foot of the cross. Early drama adapting classical narratives might also be treated, or saints' plays in which suffering is seen as sacrifice of or by family. Possible themes could include:

- Dramatic strategies for indicating typologies of sacrifice
- Sacrifice and religious ritual
- The gendering of sacrifice: do mothers and daughters suffer differently from fathers and sons?
- The positioning of the spectator in relation to suffering and violence
- Affective responses- why do sacrifice narratives "work"?
- The material staging of violence: how did they do it?
- Modern presentations of sacrifice: how can challenging plays from the past be appropriately played today?
- Religious sacrifice on stage presented to further secular interests
- Comparative sacrifice - the same story pattern enacted in different religious traditions

Please send short proposals (around 300 words) and a brief bio note to elisabeth.dutton@unifr.ch by October 15th, 2026.